

Dr Weliton Menário Costa (Dr WELI)

Scientist-artist · creative innovator · Founder and Creative Director, WildWooHoo

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Brazilian citizen (by birth) · **Italian (EU) citizen**, by descent, recognised 21 March 2023 · **Australian citizen**, conferred 23 September 2026. **The Italian citizenship means no visa, permit or sponsorship is required to work or travel in the EU.** · Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (intermediate) · NSW Working with Children Check WWC2779967E, to 01/12/2028

PROFILE

I am a scientist-artist who turns complex ideas into creative experiences, joining behavioural-ecology research (PhD, ANU) with music, film, performance and public programs. My research-creation project *Kangaroo Time* was the **AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024**. I coined and defined **sci pop**, the genre term for popular songs that carry science as aesthetic, theme or method, in a citable founding text. I direct, and I perform in what I direct. Through my studio, *WildWooHoo*, I design keynotes, workshops, performances, educational programs and original productions, and I write on science in popular culture as a Visiting Fellow at ANU's Centre for the Public Awareness of Science. **Length of professional creative practice:** sixteen years of scientific practice and more than five years of professional creative practice. Performing ran right through the doctorate, 2017 to 2021, and a field photograph of mine is published and credited to me in my 2021 ANU thesis (Figure 2, p. 15).

EUROPE: THE RECORD THAT ALREADY EXISTS

German public TV	UFA Show & Factual GmbH (Cologne, a Fremantle company) licensed the <i>Kangaroo Time</i> footage in 2024 for <i>Wer weiß denn sowas?!</i> (ARD, Das Erste), illustrating a quiz question on the research behind it. Four-year licence, credited "WELI - Kangaroo Time, from ANU".
Austrian press	<i>Kleine Zeitung</i> , 29 February 2024, Chronik: "Australischer Känguru-Forscher wird zur 'globalen Tanz-Sensation'". kleinezeitung.at/artikel/18228448
German press	<i>Süddeutsche Zeitung</i> , 27 February 2024, Panorama: "Von Kängurus lernen: Preis für Tanzvideo". sueddeutsche.de/panorama/...1.6401819
Greece, 2025	<i>Athens Science Festival</i> , with <i>SciCo Greece</i> , May 2025. My workshop <i>Science and the People</i> , delivered to a European audience.
Germany, 2025	<i>Falling Walls Engage</i> , Berlin. Top 30 worldwide , for <i>Science and the People</i> .

SIGNATURE CONTRIBUTIONS AND COINED TERMS

- **"Complex ideas into creative experiences"**: my positioning and practice, sourcing from research, reports and strategy and giving ideas a form audiences remember.
- **"Sci pop"**: a genre term I coined for popular songs that carry science as aesthetic, theme or method, ranging from real research to the fictional cultural imaginary. What makes a song sci pop is intention: sourcing from science, and bringing scientific thinking into the songwriting and production. Founding text deposited and citable, Zenodo 2026, CC BY 4.0: doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21387515.
- **The five-step live-experience method**, run by every energiser, workshop, keynote and performance: (1) start together, in movement, out of static, before any idea; (2) bring in the idea and find its human angle; (3) translate it into music, movement, story or image so people feel it; (4) make it together, so people take part and make something with the idea; (5) leave one clear thing they keep and can act on. **Principles:** participation and co-creation · inclusion and access · culture and belonging · emotion and wonder · translation and language.
- **The Interconnected Narrative method**: my making method for composing science-sourced artwork, where one unit of the work is literally true inside the scientific narrative and inside the human narrative at the same time.

SELECTED CREATIVE AND ARTISTIC PRODUCTION

2024	<i>Kangaroo Time</i> song, film, dance work	Made from my own doctoral research on kangaroo personality. I co-wrote the song, and wrote, cast, directed and performed in the film, with a dance cast of twenty-four drawn from multicultural Canberra, none of them performers by trade. AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024 , the overall prize across all four categories. Dance Your PhD edit · Kids edit
2024	<i>Cabra da Peste (G.O.A.T.)</i> original Latin pop song	Built from my own undergraduate research on goat social hierarchy, commissioned for and performed at the opening plenary of the XLI Encontro Anual de Etologia, Brazil, on the theme "Creativity and Science unifying communities". Co-written and performed with Jon Panic (Black Bird Hum). The talk and the song were one commission.
2023 to 2024	<i>The Photography Project</i> staged portrait series	Translating the doctoral findings into people. Shot 2023, released 2024. Concept and creative direction mine; photographed by Tony Oliver and Reid Workman.
Released	<i>Yours Academically, Dr. WELI</i> EP	Science, queer and Latin-immigrant narratives across reggaeton, electronic and Brazilian funk. Released and streamable catalogue: drweli.com/music .
Ongoing	<i>Kangaroo Time Kids</i> schools program	Translating the research into science, music and movement for students, taught directly to classes.
2024	<i>Sync catalogue</i>	Cleared catalogue for television, film, documentary, advertising and brand work. International sync placements across three broadcasters.
In development	<i>EVER+GROW · Kanga-Kangaroo · field-guide booklets</i>	First sci pop album, recording December 2026, launch Q2 2027 · animated series · science booklets for young readers, launch planned 2027.
2020 to now	<i>Broader performance, dance and screen</i>	Led guided dance-fitness classes and Brazilian-hits choreography with Só Samba Canberra and Rio Samba Shows, 2022 to 2024, including teaching at Blank, 2023; still performs Brazilian carnival sets with the crew at ACT festivals. Dance-fitness training, 2021. Screen extra, including <i>Young Rock</i> (Gold Coast, 2021, via 888 Agency); photographic modelling (Victoria Models, 2020). APRA AMCOS songwriter member since 2023 ; AIR Artist member 2026; artsACT Artist Database .

KEYNOTES, PERFORMANCE AND PUBLIC PROGRAMMING

Co-host, *The Visionaries Among Us*, ANU 80th anniversary, Manning Clark Hall, August 2026, with Lee Constable, on deep human history, large language models and deep space · **Opening plenary** with the commissioned performance of *Cabra da Peste*, Encontro Anual de Etologia, Brazil, 2024 · **Three Minute Thesis half-time show**, Llewellyn Hall, ANU, 2024 · **Athens Science Festival** with *SciCo Greece*, 2025 · **Floriade**, Canberra, 2025 · **Canberra Multicultural Festival** · **ACT National Science Week**, 2024 and 2025, with Inspiring Australia ACT · **ANU HDR Research Festival** · **Guest lecture**, ANU Centre for the Public Awareness of Science · **ANU Commencement 2025**, co-master of ceremonies · **Resilience Workshop**, closing keynote · *Falling Walls Engage*, Berlin, 2025, **Top 30 worldwide**. **Formats:** keynotes and conference energisers · science-art residencies and

commissions · festival and community engagement · university and Dance Your PhD workshops · the Kangaroo Time Kids classroom program. For corporate, university, school, festival and public audiences across Australia, Brazil, Europe, the United Kingdom and the United States. Full record: wildwoohoo.com/engagement.

RESEARCH

I run three strands, and my artistic practice sits inside them: peer-reviewed science underneath, current academic research into how science lives in popular culture, and creative research that feeds directly into what I make. **The making and the studying happen together.**

Behavioural ecology	Menário Costa, W., King, W. J., Bonnet, T., Festa-Bianchet, M., and Kruuk, L. E. B. (2023). Early-life behavior, survival, and maternal personality in a wild marsupial. <i>Behavioral Ecology</i> , 34(6), 1002 to 1012. · Doctoral thesis: Menário Costa, W. (2021). <i>Personality, social environment, and maternal-level effects: insights from a wild kangaroo population</i> , 266 pp, ANU. Supervisors: Prof. Loeske Kruuk (ANU) and Prof. Marco Festa-Bianchet (Université de Sherbrooke). Four years of quantitative field research on a wild eastern grey kangaroo population underpins it.
Science in popular culture	Visiting Fellow (Honorary), ANU Centre for the Public Awareness of Science . Research line: science in music and popular culture. Collaborator: Dr Anna-Sophie Jürgens. Oversight: Prof. Sujatha Raman. · <i>Principles of effective engagement with music in and for science communication</i> , with Jürgens, Graham Walker and Gypsy Cook (ANU CPAS), in preparation , with <i>Kangaroo Time</i> as a worked case. · <i>Ack! Ack! Aliens</i> , <i>Camp Science and Science Communication in Film</i> , with Jürgens, Karina Judd and Anastasiya Fiadotava, proposing "camp science" through science-fiction cinema, in review for the Routledge volume <i>Humour and Science Communication</i> .
Creative research	Menário Costa, W. (2026). <i>Sci pop: science as aesthetic, theme and method in contemporary popular music</i> . Zenodo, CC BY 4.0, doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21387515 . The founding text coining and defining the term. · <i>The Interconnected Narrative method</i> , artistic-research article on the science-to-artwork composition method, in preparation .
Forward directions	At the intersection of comparative cognition, cultural cognition and cultural musicology: human and animal cognition and social-system parallels · cultural cognition and routine thinking, the transmitted templates about nature and the species we share the planet with · collective imaginaries and emotion in music and popular culture · the evolved brain in synthetic environments. Full profile: drweli.com/academic .

POSITIONS, AFFILIATIONS AND THE STUDIO

2025 to 2027	Visiting Fellow (Honorary) CPAS , ANU College of Systems and Society	Research on science in music and popular culture. Renewed for a second term.
2026 to present	Founder and Creative Director WildWooHoo	Creative innovation studio; practice since 2024. Takes complex ideas from research papers, reports and strategy documents and turns them into creative experiences. Four formats plus a partnership: keynotes · workshops for teams, students and HDR researchers · consultancy in public engagement, communication and program design · commissioned music, film and educational materials · a 6 to 12 month Creative Research Engagement Partnership with one organisation at a time. Audiences: corporate, universities, schools (STEAM incursions), science x art. wildwoohoo.com/work · /method-drweli.com/program
2025 to 2026	Research Data Scientist UNSW	Student-experience and academic-quality analytics.
2019 to 2021	University Tutor Research School of Biology, ANU	Animal behaviour, ecology and statistical thinking.
2019 to 2020	Queer Officer PARSA, ANU	LGBTQ+ inclusion events across science and the arts.

RECOGNITION, FUNDING AND COLLABORATORS

Awards	AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024 , for <i>Kangaroo Time</i> , the overall prize across all four categories, AU\$4,000 · Falling Walls Engage Top 30 worldwide 2025 , for <i>Science and the People</i> · Judge , AAAS Dance Your PhD, 2025.
Funding	Social Policy Group , 2024, AU\$20,000 excl. GST, for CALD-inclusive events combining science and music, delivered and acquitted · ACT National Science Week / Inspiring Australia ACT , 2024, AU\$1,700, for <i>Cabra da Peste</i> , delivered and acquitted · Holsworth Wildlife Research Endowment , 2017 to 2020, field-research funding for the kangaroo doctorate · ANU International PhD Scholarship , 2017 to 2020, approx. AU\$26,288 per year, and ANU HDR Fee Remission Merit Scholarship , 2017 to 2021.
Collaborators	Jon Panic (Black Bird Hum), co-writer and performer, <i>Cabra da Peste</i> · Nic Vevers (ANU Science), production, <i>Kangaroo Time</i> video · Nicholas Moynihan , soundscape and composition · Dr Anna-Sophie Jürgens (ANU CPAS), research collaborator · Simon Clews (ANU), HDR student development and the 3MT half-time show · Tony Oliver and Reid Workman , photography.

MEDIA

238+ media features across five continents for *Kangaroo Time* (Isentia 2024; estimated potential reach above 15 million). Full coverage: drweli.com/media. Selected: *Science* (AAAS, 26 Feb 2024) · *The Guardian*, "Joyful madness: ANU scientist wins global prize for dancing his PhD about kangaroos", 27 Feb 2024 · *Smithsonian Magazine*, 28 Feb 2024 · *MSNBC The 11th Hour* with Stephanie Ruhle, "Last Thing Before We Go: Kangaroo Time", 1 Mar 2024 · *NPR*, Morning Edition and All Things Considered, Mar and May 2024 · *Kleine Zeitung* (Austria), 29 Feb 2024 · *Süddeutsche Zeitung* (Germany), 27 Feb 2024 · *O Globo* (Brazil), 29 Feb 2024 · ABC News (Australia) · BBC · Australian Geographic · Cosmos · LGBT Nation.

EDUCATION, TRAINING AND CAPABILITIES

2017 to 2021	PhD, Ecology and Evolution , The Australian National University. Supervisors: Prof. Loeske Kruuk and Prof. Marco Festa-Bianchet. Thesis as above, 266 pp.
from 2010	Licenciatura and Bacharelado, Biological Sciences , Instituto Federal do Espírito Santo , Brazil, with a Science Without Borders exchange at Griffith University, Australia, 2013 to 2014.
2025 to 2026	Voice and songwriting , Open Academy, Sydney Conservatorium of Music, University of Sydney, four short courses, plus private voice and performance coaching (ANU School of Music, NIDA short courses, Canberra vocal coaches).

Capabilities: creative direction · science communication and research translation · songwriting, with production delivered through studio producers and collaborators · live performance and dance · film and audiovisual scripting and creative direction, with videography and editing outsourced · workshop facilitation and program design · keynote speaking · experimental design, field data collection, quantitative analysis and scientific writing · bilingual delivery in English and Portuguese, with short sessions also in Spanish.